FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

ENCOURAGE A GROWTH MINDSET

Praise the work, not the gift

06

THE QUICK VERSION

> When we praise effort, persistence and attitude, kids learn that ability grows with work. When we mostly praise natural talent, they can become afraid of anything that might make them look less talented, including trying hard things and making mistakes.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Psychologist Carol Dweck's research describes two mindsets. A fixed mindset says "I'm just not good with my left foot." A growth mindset says "I can't use my left foot well yet." Kids with a growth mindset take on challenges, bounce back from mistakes and keep improving, and the way we praise them helps build it.

Praise the hard work, not the result

Offering praise for hard work communicates your support without attaching your love to their performance. Your child learns that what you value is who they are and how they show up, not whether they scored.

PRAISE THAT HELPS THEM GROW

GROWTH PRAISE

- ✓ "You kept practising until you got it."
- ✓ "I love that you tried the hard skill."
- ✓ "Your attitude after that mistake was awesome."
- ✓ "You've really improved since last month."

TALENT-ONLY PRAISE

- × "You're a natural."
- × "You're the best on the team."
- × "You never make mistakes."
- × "You're better than all of them."

TRY THIS

1 Add the word "yet"
"I can't do it" becomes "I can't do it yet." Small word, big shift.

2 Make mistakes normal
Share your own mistakes at work or home and what you learned from them.

3 Set process goals
"100 left-foot touches this week" beats "score more goals."

4 Compare to last month, not to others
Progress against themselves is what really counts.

5 Be specific
"You stayed calm under pressure" teaches more than "Well done."

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"You worked so hard for that."	~~"You're just naturally gifted."~~
"Mistakes mean you're learning."	~~"Don't make that mistake again."~~
"You can't do it yet. Keep going."	~~"Maybe you're just not good at that."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] I praise effort and attitude more than talent
- [ ] My child hears me talk about my own mistakes
- [ ] We celebrate improvement, not just results
- [ ] My child is willing to try things they find hard

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

"Talent gets you noticed. Hard work, curiosity and the way you respond to mistakes are what keep you in the game."

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM